Why China Cares About Being Cool All of a Sudden

中国为何突然在意“酷”起来

Jan. 30, 2026 11:00 pm ET

2026年1月30日 晚上11:00 ET

It was America’s day of giving thanks, and China was having a moment.

那是美国感恩的日子，而中国正迎来它的高光时刻。

A giant float with fang-baring toy monsters was trundling through Manhattan for the Macy’s Thanksgiving Day Parade, as crowds of onlookers whipped out their phones to capture the looming 16-foot balloons—Chinese soft-power icons starring in one of America’s biggest cultural events.

一个载有露齿玩具怪物的巨型花车正缓慢地穿过曼哈顿，参加梅西感恩节大游行，成群的旁观者纷纷拿出手机，拍摄那些高耸的16英尺气球——这些中国软实力标志性形象正在美国最大的文化活动之一中亮相。

The spectacle marked new heights in the global craze around Labubu dolls, created by a Hong Kong artist and sold by Beijing-based toy maker Pop Mart. For the past year, the mania had been growing: Lady Gaga accessorized a Labubu on her Hermès purse; Cher, David Beckham and Marc Jacobs also clipped the accessory to their bags. The dolls became so hard to come by that some were resold for as much as 20 times their retail prices, while zealous fans traveled to China to hunt down fast-selling goods. Now Pop Mart is opening a 7,000 square foot flagship store in Manhattan’s Times Square, with even more stories planned in malls across America.

这一盛况标志着围绕Labubu玩偶的全球热潮达到了新高度，这些玩偶由一位香港艺术家创作，并由北京的玩具制造商泡泡玛特销售。过去一年里，这股狂热持续升温：Lady Gaga将一个Labubu挂在她的爱马仕包上；雪儿、大卫·贝克汉姆和马克·雅布斯也把这个配饰夹在他们的包上。这些玩偶变得如此稀有，以至于有些被转售的价格高达零售价的20倍，而热情的粉丝们则前往中国抢购热销商品。现在，泡泡玛特正在曼哈顿时代广场开设一家7000平方英尺的旗舰店，并计划在美国各地的购物中心开设更多门店。

The hype around Chinese cultural goods is giving Beijing’s global profile some timely gloss, just as American soft power is losing some of its sheen. China has long coveted the immense influence the U.S. enjoys through its cultural appeal, and President Trump, with his trade wars, chaotic diplomacy and military actions, has created openings for Beijing to polish its pitch of being a benign and responsible power.

围绕中国文化产品的热潮，正及时为北京的全球形象增添光彩，而与此同时，美国的软实力正在失去一些光泽。中国长期以来一直觊觎美国通过其文化魅力所享有的巨大影响力，而特朗普总统的贸易战、混乱的外交和军事行动，为北京提供了机会，使其能够更好地宣传自己是一个良性且负责任的大国。

Enter fluffy dolls and online influencers into this geopolitical arena. For decades, China has tried making friends abroad through staid state-led initiatives, from sharing pandas to building language institutes. Today, the Communist Party has decided it should sometimes let the cultural free market do the job. (Exhibit A: TikTok.) Now, commercial successes from trendy trinkets like Labubus to blockbuster films and videogames are helping to define China’s standing on the world stage.

蓬松的玩偶和网络红人进入了这个地缘政治舞台。几十年来，中国一直试图通过稳重的国家主导倡议在海外结交朋友，从分享熊猫到建立语言学院。如今，共产党决定有时应让文化自由市场来完成这项工作。（例证A：TikTok。）现在，从Labubu等时尚小饰品到卖座电影和电子游戏的商业成功，正在帮助塑造中国在世界舞台上的地位。

The hit 2025 movie “Ne Zha 2,” which features an imp battling demons and deities, became the first animated film and non-Hollywood production to gross more than $2 billion globally, showcasing China’s ambitions to compete with the likes of Disney. A martial arts role-playing game “Black Myth: Wukong,” inspired by the classical Chinese novel “Journey to the West,” notched record-breaking sales after its release in 2024 and lapped up rave reviews from Western gamers.

2025年上映的热门电影《哪吒2》，讲述了一个小妖与恶魔和神灵战斗的故事，成为首部全球票房超过20亿美元的动画电影和非好莱坞制作，展示了中国与迪士尼等公司竞争的雄心。武侠角色扮演游戏《黑神话：悟空》灵感来源于中国古典小说《西游记》，于2024年发布后创下了破纪录的销量，并获得了西方玩家的热烈好评。

When Chinese products find that kind of resonance abroad, officials and state media rush in to talk up these smash-hit products as signs of China’s growing cultural appeal, and give them a further leg up in the marketplace.

当中国产品在海外获得这种共鸣时，官员和官方媒体会迅速介入，将这些热门产品宣传为中国日益增长的文化魅力的标志，并进一步提升它们在市场上的地位。

As Pop Mart reported skyrocketing Labubu sales over the past two years, state media lauded the plushies as proof that China can drive global consumer trends, while regulators cracked down on Labubu counterfeits to protect what had become a major cultural export. Beijing paired its praise for “Black Myth: Wukong” with a dialing back of regulatory pressure on the videogame industry. Local authorities also have welcomed foreign influencers to help present China’s mix of ancient culture and ultramodern infrastructure to global audiences.

随着泡泡玛特报告过去两年Labubu销量飞速上涨，官方媒体赞扬这些毛绒玩具是中国能够引领全球消费趋势的证明，同时监管机构打击了Labubu的假冒产品，以保护这一已成为主要文化出口的商品。北京将对《黑神话：悟空》的赞扬与放松对电子游戏行业的监管压力结合起来。地方当局也欢迎外国网红帮助向全球观众展示中国古代文化与超现代基础设施的结合。

This new playbook marks a rare instance when the Communist Party is reining in its instincts to micromanage society, particularly under Chinese leader Xi Jinping, who has sought to restore the party as the dominant force in people’s lives—such as by tightening state control over private businesses and public speech. The party’s longer leash for some creative industries is helping to boost cultural output that had been stifled by regulatory scrutiny in recent years.

这一新策略标志着共产党罕见地克制了其微观管理社会的本能，尤其是在中国领导人习近平的领导下，他一直致力于恢复党在人民生活中的主导地位——例如通过加强国家对私营企业和公共言论的控制。党对一些创意产业的“放长线”做法，正在帮助提振近年来因监管审查而受到压制的文化产出。

“The party has understood that it cannot design soft power in a meeting room,” said Shaoyu Yuan, an adjunct professor at New York University’s Center for Global Affairs. “The current strategy looks more like this: Let creativity grow inside the system, as long as it does not cross clear political red lines, and then support the winners.”

纽约大学全球事务中心兼职教授袁少宇表示：“党已经明白，软实力无法在会议室里设计出来。”“目前的策略更像是：让创意在体制内生长，只要不越过明确的政治红线，然后支持那些成功者。”

Xi himself offered a rare endorsement. “Wukong and Ne Zha are global hits,” he said in his New Year’s address. “Classic Chinese culture has become the finest form of aesthetic expression in the eyes of young people.”

习近平本人罕见地表达了认可。他在新年致辞中说：“悟空和哪吒是全球热门作品。”“经典中国文化已成为年轻人眼中最精美的审美表达形式。”

For Beijing, boosting cultural exports can help push back against Western depictions of China as a military threat, cybersecurity menace and cheap-goods exporter that Trump claims has been ripping off America. Soft-power tools complement other efforts to boost China’s sway, from infrastructure investments in developing countries to more insidious forms of outreach—such as political-influence campaigns in the U.S. and elsewhere.

对北京而言，提振文化出口有助于反击西方将中国描绘成军事威胁、网络安全威胁以及特朗普声称“剥削美国”的廉价商品出口国的形象。软实力工具补充了其他提升中国影响力的努力，从对发展中国家的基础设施投资，到更隐蔽的对外宣传形式——例如在美国和其他地方的政治影响力运动。

The party’s embrace of grassroots-led cultural creations also adds to traditional soft-power campaigns that tap China’s ancient past and natural riches. “Many foreigners’ perceptions of China may still be stuck at kung fu, the Great Wall and pandas. Now, through trendy collectibles, they are seeing a China full of creativity and attuned to young people’s needs,” a party-run newspaper said. “Through these trend icons, China is reshaping the world’s perceptions of who we are.”

党对基层主导的文化创作的拥抱，也补充了利用中国古代历史和自然财富的传统软实力宣传活动。一份党报称：“许多外国人对中国的看法可能仍停留在功夫、长城和熊猫上。现在，通过时尚收藏品，他们看到了一个充满创意、与年轻人需求同步的中国。”“通过这些潮流偶像，中国正在重塑世界对我们是谁的认知。”

Success could yield more receptive audiences for China’s efforts to expand its economic reach, assert its interests and challenge the U.S. for global leadership. Recent surveys show warming sentiment toward China, particularly in the developing world and among youth—narrowing Beijing’s soft-power gap with Washington as Trump’s “America First” agenda rankles allies and partners.

成功可能为中国拓展经济影响力、维护自身利益以及挑战美国全球领导地位的努力，带来更多接受度高的受众。最近的调查显示，对中国的感情正在升温，尤其是在发展中国家和年轻人中——随着特朗普的“美国优先”议程激怒盟友和伙伴，北京与华盛顿之间的软实力差距正在缩小。

“Beijing benefits when the U.S. damages its own standing or retreats from global leadership, but China’s own efforts to project state-sponsored soft power have produced mixed results,” said Lizzi Lee, a fellow at the Asia Society Policy Institute. Cultural creation in the private sector, she said, “is where China has been far more effective.”

亚洲协会政策研究所研究员李梓说：“当美国损害自身地位或退出全球领导地位时，北京会受益，但中国自身推行国家资助的软实力的努力却收效不一。”她表示，私营部门的文化创作“是中国更有效的地方”。

The party also reaps domestic gains from its push for cultural appeal. Beijing is “telling domestic audiences: ‘Our culture is strong, our creators can compete with Disney and Marvel, and the party is the guardian of this rise,’” said Yuan, the NYU scholar. “The external influence matters, but the internal message about legitimacy is always central.”

党从其推动文化魅力的努力中也获得了国内收益。纽约大学学者袁说，北京正在“告诉国内受众：‘我们的文化很强大，我们的创作者可以与迪士尼和漫威竞争，而党是这一崛起的守护者。’” “外部影响力固然重要，但关于合法性的内部信息始终是核心。”

The party’s lighter-touch on culture comes amid the rise of a trusted adviser in Xi’s inner circle, Li Shulei. A former literature professor at the Communist Party’s top training academy, where he was once a deputy to Xi, Li has long urged China to foster pride in its heritage and brace for a culture war with America.

党对文化采取更宽松的态度，正值习近平核心圈子中一位值得信赖的顾问李书磊崛起。李书磊曾是中共最高党校的文学教授，也曾是习近平的副手，他长期以来一直敦促中国培养对自身传统的自豪感，并为与美国的文化战做好准备。

Since becoming the party’s propaganda minister in 2022, Li has championed Xi’s program to invoke Chinese arts, traditions and history to justify Communist rule and boost Beijing’s soft power. “The more we face containment and suppression, the more we must promote open cooperation in the cultural field, and showcase a credible, lovely and respectable image of China,“ Li told a forum in May.

自2022年成为党的宣传部长以来，李书磊一直倡导习近平的计划，即援引中国艺术、传统和历史来证明共产党的统治合法性并提升北京的软实力。李书磊在5月的一个论坛上表示：“我们越是面临遏制和压制，就越要促进文化领域的开放合作，展示一个可信、可爱、可敬的中国形象。”

A state-run news portal credited a Li essay with shaping Xi’s views on improving the party’s public messaging through livelier language. As a literary critic, Li argued that China must cultivate confidence in its culture to prevent society from falling into disorder. He singled out the U.S. as a leading threat, writing essays that criticized what he described as American arrogance and the corrosive influence of American consumerism—views that prompted peers to call him a “culture warrior.”

一家官方新闻门户网站认为，李书磊的一篇文章塑造了习近平关于通过更生动的语言改进党的公共宣传的观点。作为一名文学评论家，李书磊认为中国必须培养文化自信，以防止社会陷入混乱。他将美国列为主要威胁，撰写文章批评他所描述的美国傲慢和美国消费主义的腐蚀性影响——这些观点促使同行称他为“文化战士”。

“Since powerful foreign countries are so open about using culture as a weapon against other nations, we have no choice but to respond in kind and strive to enhance our country’s ‘soft power,’” Li told a Chinese newspaper in 2007.

李书磊在2007年告诉一家中国报纸：“既然强大的外国如此公开地将文化作为对抗其他国家的武器，我们别无选择，只能以牙还牙，努力提升我国的‘软实力’。”

Some analysts credit Li with steering the party toward giving public praise, providing creators with intellectual-property protection or financial incentives, and injecting these products into official narratives about China’s global stature.

一些分析人士认为，李书磊引导党走向公开赞扬、为创作者提供知识产权保护或财政激励，并将这些产品融入关于中国全球地位的官方叙事中。

Embracing foreign influencers is part of the strategy. When IShowSpeed, a popular American streamer named Darren Watkins Jr., toured China last spring, the country’s officials fanned online buzz about his trip, praising “Hyperthyroid Bro”—as he is known in Chinese—for presenting an authentic view of the country. A segment on state television featured what it called a “fantastical China tour,” and recounted how IShowSpeed tasted Chinese delicacies, visited landmarks including the Great Wall and the ancient Buddhist Shaolin Temple, and visited a traditional Chinese medicine store, where he tried acupuncture.

拥抱外国网红是该策略的一部分。去年春天，当美国知名主播小达伦·沃特金斯（IShowSpeed）游览中国时，中国官员们在网上大肆宣传他的行程，称赞“甲亢哥”（他在中国的昵称）展现了中国真实的一面。国家电视台的一个节目播出了所谓的“奇幻中国之旅”，讲述了IShowSpeed如何品尝中国美食，参观了包括长城和古老的少林寺在内的地标，并参观了一家传统中药店，在那里他尝试了针灸。

Watkins’ livestreams encouraged “Chinese people to re-examine their lives” and cherish their country’s achievements, Zhejiang province’s propaganda department said on social media. “Many Chinese netizens realized: ‘The life we ■■take for granted is actually a luxury in the eyes of others.’”

浙江省宣传部在社交媒体上表示，沃特金斯的直播鼓励“中国人重新审视自己的生活”，并珍惜国家的成就。“许多中国网民意识到：‘我们习以为常的生活，在别人眼中其实是一种奢侈。’”

The same enthusiasm applied to the videogame “Black Myth: Wukong,” which came as China eased regulatory pressure on its videogame industry. This was a reversal of Beijing’s tightened oversight in recent years, with authorities at one point halting approvals of videogame licenses after Xi voiced concern in 2021 about gaming addiction among Chinese youth.

同样的enthusiasmo也适用于电子游戏《黑神话：悟空》，该游戏发布时正值中国放松对电子游戏行业的监管压力。这扭转了北京近年来收紧监管的局面，此前在2021年习近平对中国青少年游戏成瘾表示担忧后，当局曾一度暂停批准电子游戏许可证。

As the game flourished, Beijing shifted its tone, calling it an artful representation of Chinese culture, which helped revive investor interest and drive up share prices for videogame companies in China. Chinese regulators have also issued more videogame licenses, approving 1,771 titles last year—a 25% increase from 2024.

随着游戏的蓬勃发展，北京改变了口径，称其为中国文化的巧妙体现，这有助于重振投资者兴趣，并推高中国电子游戏公司的股价。中国监管机构也发放了更多电子游戏许可证，去年批准了1771款游戏——比2024年增加了25%。

Outside China, some players said “Black Myth: Wukong” inspired them to read “Journey to the West” or watch dramatizations of the novel, so that they could better grasp story lines and cultural references in the game. “I felt as though I were a little more connected to a culture, a country, and its history,” said Shaz Mohsin, a Toronto-based videogame reviewer.

在中国之外，一些玩家表示，《黑神话：悟空》激发了他们阅读《西游记》或观看该小说改编剧的兴趣，以便更好地理解游戏中的故事情节和文化典故。多伦多电子游戏评论员沙兹·莫辛说：“我感觉自己与一种文化、一个国家及其历史的联系更紧密了。”

To Lee at the Asia Society, that kind of response is exactly the point. These cultural products “succeed because they feel spontaneous, playful, sometimes a bit subversive,” Lee said. “The party wants to harness the soft-power upside without giving up control over the narrative.”

在亚洲协会的李梓看来，这种反响正是关键所在。李梓说，这些文化产品“之所以成功，是因为它们感觉是自发的、有趣的，有时甚至带有一点颠覆性。”“党希望利用软实力的优势，同时又不放弃对叙事的控制。”

Appeared in the January 31, 2026, print edition as 'Why China Wants You to Love Labubus'.

刊登于2026年1月31日印刷版，标题为《中国为何希望你爱上Labubu》。

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Chun Han was part of a team of Journal reporters named as Pulitzer Prize finalists in 2021 for their coverage of China’s autocratic turn under Xi Jinping. His book on Xi's leadership, "Party of One: The Rise of Xi Jinping and China's Superpower Future," was published by Avid Reader Press in May 2023.

黄春汉是《华尔街日报》记者团队的一员，该团队因报道习近平领导下中国走向专制而在2021年被提名为普利策奖决赛入围者。他关于习近平领导力的著作《一人之党：习近平的崛起与中国的超级大国未来》于2023年5月由Avid Reader Press出版。

A graduate of the London School of Economics, Chun Han started reporting for the Journal and Dow Jones Newswires in 2010, first covering politics and business in Singapore, Cambodia and the broader Southeast Asian region.

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TOEIC Vocabulary Study
托业词汇学习

1. trundling
/ˈtrʌndlɪŋ/

EN: moving slowly and heavily, typically with a rolling or rumbling sound.
缓慢而沉重地移动，通常伴有滚动或隆隆声。

"A giant float with fang-baring toy monsters was trundling through Manhattan for the Macy's Thanksgiving Day Parade."
"一个载有露齿玩具怪物的巨型花车正缓慢地穿过曼哈顿，参加梅西感恩节大游行。"

2. onlookers
/ˈɒnlʊkərz/

EN: people who watch an event or incident without taking part.
旁观者，围观者。

"crowds of onlookers whipped out their phones to capture the looming 16-foot balloons."
"成群的旁观者纷纷拿出手机，拍摄那些高耸的16英尺气球。"

3. zealous
/ˈzɛləs/

EN: having or showing great energy or enthusiasm in pursuit of a cause or objective.
热情的，热忱的，积极的。

"zealous fans traveled to China to hunt down fast-selling goods."
"热情的粉丝们前往中国抢购热销商品。"

4. coveted
/ˈkʌvɪtɪd/

EN: greatly desired or envied.
梦寐以求的，令人垂涎的。

"China has long coveted the immense influence the U.S. enjoys through its cultural appeal."
"中国长期以来一直觊觎美国通过其文化魅力所享有的巨大影响力。"

5. benign
/bɪˈnaɪn/

EN: gentle and kind; not harmful in effect.
温和的，良性的；无害的。

"Trump, with his trade wars, chaotic diplomacy and military actions, has created openings for Beijing to polish its pitch of being a benign and responsible power."
"特朗普的贸易战、混乱的外交和军事行动，为北京提供了机会，使其能够更好地宣传自己是一个良性且负责任的大国。"

6. staid
/steɪd/

EN: respectable, serious, and old-fashioned.
稳重的，严肃的，守旧的。

"For decades, China has tried making friends abroad through staid state-led initiatives, from sharing pandas to building language institutes."
"几十年来，中国一直试图通过稳重的国家主导倡议在海外结交朋友，从分享熊猫到建立语言学院。"

7. skyrocketing
/ˈskaɪˌrɒkɪtɪŋ/

EN: increasing very rapidly.
飞速上涨的，猛增的。

"As Pop Mart reported skyrocketing Labubu sales over the past two years, state media lauded the plushies as proof that China can drive global consumer trends."
"随着泡泡玛特报告过去两年Labubu销量飞速上涨，官方媒体赞扬这些毛绒玩具是中国能够引领全球消费趋势的证明。"

8. reining in
/ˈreɪnɪŋ ɪn/

EN: to control or limit something, especially something that is growing or increasing too quickly.
控制，限制（尤指增长过快的事物）。

"This new playbook marks a rare instance when the Communist Party is reining in its instincts to micromanage society."

"这一新策略标志着共产党罕见地克制了其微观管理社会的本能。"

9. endorsement

/ɪnˈdɔːrsmənt/

EN: an act of giving one's public approval or support to someone or something.

认可，支持；代言。

"Xi himself offered a rare endorsement."

"习近平本人罕见地表达了认可。"

10. cultivate

/ˈkʌltɪveɪt/

EN: try to acquire or develop (a quality, sentiment, or skill).

培养，发展（某种品质、情感或技能）。

"Li argued that China must cultivate confidence in its culture to prevent society from falling into disorder."

"李认为，中国必须培养文化自信，以防止社会陷入混乱。"